

GG

Gg is another of the Witsuwit'en back of the throat sounds. Remember that even though it is written with two letters, **gg** represents a single sound. **Gg** doesn't really have an equivalent in English. **gg** is always followed by a vowel and cannot occur word-finally (actually syllable-finally).

Examples of GG

Here are some examples:

ggis	'spring salmon'
ggikh	'rabbit'
ggunek	'hummingbird'
sikh ggis	'gaff pole'
c'its'isggek	'chickadee'
nilggeyh	'he/she is running around'
ho'ggec	'nothing'
yizggis	'he/she sprained it'

The tricky thing about **gg** is that some speakers pronounce this sound identically to **k**. (That is, those speakers don't seem to have the sound **gg**.) In the dictionary, we'll write the above words and others with **gg** and it will be understood that for some speakers this sound is not different from **k**. (Note: This seems to be a Witsuwit'en innovation in pronunciation, with Moricetown possibly at the epicenter of the innovation. Burns Lake, Fort Babine, etc. always has **gg**.)

GG vs. G

In this section we will compare **gg** and **g**. This comparison is parallel to one we went over above, **k** and **c**. In fact, **k : c :: gg : g**.

Examples of G

The sound represented by Witsuwit'en **g** may sound to you like it has a *y* after it. It is in fact a lot like English *g* in *argue*.

gen	'here; old age'
gis	'hook'
sgiz	'he/she is breathing'
nigit	'fear'
hillhgit	'it's rotting'
'igeqh	'it happened'
gin/ginih	'don't', as in:
nulggeyh gin	'don't run around'

Like **gg**, **g** can only occur before a vowel, never word-finally (syllable-finally).

Gg vs. G

ts'ilhggä 'we dried it'	ts'ilhgi 'grebe'
ggin 'that person'	gin 'don't'
Udiggi 'God'	digi 'huckleberry'



ggit ‘there’

ggis ‘spring salmon’

tsëggis ‘fire poker’

ggunek ‘hummingbird’

git ‘old, rotten’, as in:

halho’ git ‘rag’ (lit. ‘rotten cloth’)

gïstan ‘6’

gis ‘hook’

’uguni ‘porcupine’

GG vs. GH

Examples of GH

Gh is another back of the throat sound. There is nothing like it in English. It is very close to the sound of *r* as pronounced by French speakers. **Gh** is actually just like another sound we have discussed, **kh**, except that the vocal cords are vibrating during **gh** (which makes the sound louder than **kh**).

Gh can occur before a vowel:

ghede’

bighu

bighe

bighewh

hitghet

tilghis

‘last year’

‘his/her tooth’

‘its fur, his/her body hair’

‘according to him/her/it’

‘he/she is shivering’

‘he/she is taking a bath’

Gh can also occur word-finally. The preceding vowel is most commonly **a**, **e** or **ë** (never **i** or **u**):

’agh

ncagh

binegh

bibegh

’et sitlëgh

’et lhc’ëgh

‘fast, early’

‘it’s big’

‘his/her/its eye’

‘around it, around its edge’

‘it (mushy object) is there’

‘he/she is sitting there mad’

GG vs. GH

dilggï ‘it’s grey’

siggï ‘it dried’

sleggï, sileggï ‘my fingernail’

ïlggïh ‘he/she is running’

dilhggis ‘it’s black’

yilhggï ‘he/she is drying it’

dilghï ‘he/she is screaming’

sghï, sighï ‘my sister- or brother-in-law’

sleghï ‘eulachon grease’

bighïh ‘its root’

yilhghis ‘it’s chewing it (hard object, leaf)’

yizilhghï ‘he/she killed it’

K vs. KH

Examples of K (review)

k is found before a vowel:

ka	‘car’
ku’	‘puppy’
nekat	‘it’s snowing’
yunkët	‘he/she bought it’
lhikit	‘he/she is clapping’
udïlhkit	‘ask him/her’

k is also found syllable-finally, such as at the end of a word:

nek	‘two’
tsëk	‘open fire, camp fire’
widek	‘on top, on drop-off’
ndzek	‘it’s lightweight’
bikak	‘its surface’
tacëk	‘mouth of river’

Examples of KH (review)

kh occurs before a vowel:

khë	‘grease’
khëlh	‘pack’
khas	‘fireweed’
khiz	‘pus’
khiy	‘root’

kh also occurs word-finally:

khikh	‘goose’
yikh	‘house’
tëkh	‘into, under water’
net’ikh	‘spruce grouse, fool hen’
dilkw’akh	‘frog’

K vs. KH

Contrasts before a vowel:

kë ‘footwear’	khë ‘grease’
bikiy ‘her husband’	khiy ‘root’
këlebes ‘bearpaw snowshoe’	khëlh ‘pack’
’et wika ‘that’s why, because of that’	’ëlikha ‘gunny sack’

Word-final contrasts:

bit’ak ‘his/her back’	bit’akh ‘under it’
bits’ëk ‘its sinew’	ts’ëkh ‘sinew’
dewesyik ‘he/she isn’t dying’	deyikh ‘he/she is dying’
widek ‘on top’	bidekh ‘its top surface’ (liquid in cup)

DZ, TS, and TS'

These phonetically similar sounds have somewhat different distributions. **dz** is normally followed by the vowels **ī ē u i**. **ts** and **ts'** are normally followed by **e ē a o i**.

dz and **ts'** do not occur at the end of a word (or syllable). Of these three sounds, only **ts** is allowed there.

Examples of DZ

dzekh	‘pitch’
ndzek	‘it’s lightweight; your hearing’
dzin	‘day’
dzut	‘coat’
bidzi	‘his/her heart’
dzihtel	‘lumber’
nīlhdze’	‘it’s far’
yizdzh	‘he/she grabbed it’

Examples of TS

Before a vowel

tsək	‘open fire, camp fire’
tša	‘beaver’
tsalic	‘squirrel’
tsak’ēt	‘hole’

Word-finally

’ats	‘outside’
tits	‘all night’
’elhits	‘permanently’
dinī bits	‘in the feast hall’
lhc’ats	‘on both sides’
kwandits	‘everywhere’

Examples of TS'

ts’ac	‘bowl, dish’
ts’ekh	‘sinew’
ts’akē, ts’ekē	‘woman’
ts’enek	‘for no reason’
hits’il	‘it’s roasting, barbecuing’
ts’ineh	‘orphan’

Words containing two of DZ, TS, or TS'

tsets	‘grandfather; from downhill’
tsēldzikw, tsēldzuc	‘comb’
c’endzits	‘drink (to child)’
ts’itsagh	‘we’re crying’

DZ vs. TS

dzen ‘muddy water’	bitsen to ‘his/her sweat’
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Remember that **dz** and **ts** have different effects on how a following **i** is pronounced. **i** sounds like English “short-u” after **ts** but closer to “short-i” after **dz**...

bidzil ‘his/her mountain’
c’ildzis ‘he/she is dancing FN style’
so’endzin ‘you’re okay’

bitsil ‘his/her diaper’
ditsis ‘whip’
tëtsin ‘he/she is weak’

...unless **k** or **kh** follows:

bidzik ‘his/her outer ear’

so’iltsic ‘it’s enough’

TS vs. TS’

tsan ‘excrement’
tsët ‘first time’
tsil ‘diaper’
bitsel ‘his/her axe’
ditsin ‘it’s dirty’
yitsë ‘it’s barking’
bitsen to ‘his/her sweat’
tsil tset ‘toilet paper’

ts’an ‘totem pole’
ts’ët ‘in the open’
ts’il ‘brush’
bits’el ‘his/her elbow’
dits’in ‘it’s stiff’
bits’ë ‘his/her umbilical cord’
ts’enco ‘swan’
lhk’iy ts’et ‘nine’

DZ vs. TS’

’et sidzec ‘they (granular objects) are there’ bits’ec ‘his/her intestines’

Here too **dz** and **ts’** affect the pronunciation of a following **i** differently. **i** sounds like English “short-u” after **ts’** but “short-i” after **dz**...

dzilh ‘mountain’
ïndzilh ‘hit it (ball)’

hilts’ilh ‘it hurts’
ïlts’ilh ‘it’s moving, going’ (letter, message, star)

...unless **k** or **kh** follows.

dzikh ‘roughly, badly’
bidzik ‘his/her outer ear’

ts’ikh ‘hat’
bits’ik ‘his/her little finger’

Writing practice 4

_____ or _____

‘rhubarb’
‘four times’
‘oolachen’
‘cottonwood, boat’
‘dog, chum salmon’

_____	‘it’s grey’
_____	‘the wood is crooked, twisted’
_____	‘he’s sawing wood’
_____ or _____	‘perpetually missing’
_____	‘it’s oval’
_____	‘packed lunch’
_____	‘eel’
_____	‘it’s bitter’
_____	‘widow, widower’
_____	‘flea’
_____	Gidimt’en chief name
_____	‘he/she came, arrived’
_____	‘his/her neck’

When you have finished, compare what you wrote with your neighbor and try to come to some agreement.

Answers to writing practice 4

ggus	‘rhubarb’
dīt	‘four times’
sac	‘oolachen’
ts’iy	‘cottonwood, boat’
ggenīs or gginīs	‘dog, chum salmon’
dilggī	‘it’s grey’
tsiz diggiz	‘the wood is crooked, twisted’
tsiz dighit	‘he’s sawing wood’
wislek or wisdlek	‘perpetually missing’
dikilh	‘it’s oval’
ts’ilim	‘packed lunch’
ts’ëlkiy’	‘eel’
ts’ilkiy’	‘it’s bitter’
tsandīlh	‘widow, widower’
ts’anīh	‘flea’
Gisdewe	Gidimt’en chief name
witsanye	‘he/she came, arrived’
bitsecin	‘his/her neck’